

Interviewer:[00:00] Good afternoon. Thank you again for participating in this interview. As I mentioned in my message, we would like to learn more about your views on romantic relationships. I believe that your experience and perspective would be very helpful for this project. Would it be okay for me to record this interview before we start? I will only use this recording to take transcription notes.

Speaker: [00:27] Agreed, I approve.

Interviewer:[00:30] Thank you. First of all, how old are you?

Speaker:[00:34] [21-25].

Interviewer:[00:37] How long have you been with your partner?

Speaker:[00:39] [1-5] years.

Interviewer:[00:43] 5. Do you have children?

Speaker:[00:45] No, I am not married.

Interviewer:[00:48] Okay. Who do you live with at home?

Speaker:[00:51] With my mother.

Interviewer:[00:53] What is your main source of income right now? What is your current job?

Speaker:[00:57] I am a [occupation].

Interviewer:[01:01] What should I call your partner? I would say your boyfriend. Your husband, your lover. What do you want me to call him?

Speaker:[01:09] You can say your lover.

Interviewer:[01:11]Your lover. Okay. Can you tell me the story of how you met and how your relationship started?

Speaker:[01:16] We met through [Social Media]. We were both at the same university, we know each other from [University]. By chance, he sent an emoji on the story I shared on [Social Media]. We responded to that emoji and met. We had midterm exams. That was the first time we met in the schoolyard. It was like that.

Interviewer:[01:40] When did you meet?

Speaker:[01:42] [Date].

Interviewer:[01:44] Okay. How did your relationship develop?

Speaker:[01:48] Our relationship actually developed very fast. It was like... How should I put it? We were like pots and pans. It wasn't very difficult. We adapted to each other immediately and we started very fast. You know relationships have a flirting period at first. We didn't have a flirtation period, but we stepped into the period of being lovers in an instant. And we maintained it. We had a flirtation period inside the relationship.

Interviewer:[02:14] Compared to your friends' relationships...how would you rate the quality of your own relationship?

Speaker:[02:20] On a number? Or do I have to say a term myself?

Interviewer:[02:25] No, by interpretation. It's completely up to you. How would you rate the quality of your relationship compared to your friends' relationship?

Speaker:[02:32] Like... You know there are two different products, [Brand] and [Brand]. Apple is better quality. Because it's the latest technology. It lasts longer. I am giving examples from my own company. I am saying these things in terms of technology. But for example, [Brand] is not as advanced and well-known as [Brand]. Our relationship is completely [Brand]. I see theirs as [Brand].

Interviewer:[02:57] Can you explain a little bit more why you say that?

Speaker:[03:00] Like this...Because, for example, [Brand] is always keeping up with the new era. It steps into new technology. It immediately gets new updates and versions. [Brand] is actually a product that is open to innovations. And it constantly gives updates. You know, it adds innovations, improves itself. It puts a little more on it. But [Brand], for example, is not like that. You know, it is a click behind [Brand]. It is not very advanced in my eyes. That's how I see our relationship. Every year we add something more to it. In every problem, we give a little more on top of it. And this is what happens. It grows and grows. It gets stronger and stronger.

Interviewer:[03:42] Can I also ask you how many romantic relationships have you had in the past?

Speaker:[03:48] How many were there? There were [1-5] more.

Interviewer:[03:52] So how would you rate the quality of your current relationship compared to your previous relationships?

Speaker:[03:58] It cannot be compared to them. I mean, my current relationship is not comparable to them. Back then it was the excitement of childhood and youth. Now it's a completely adult relationship based on logic. You know, really based on love. It's a relationship based on something that only love gives, without any interest, without any expectations from each other.

Interviewer:[04:22] So for you what makes a relationship high quality, what makes it qualified?

Speaker:[04:29] Being able to talk. I mean, if two people can talk to each other, it means they can overcome everything. Since [Partner's Name] and I can talk about everything together, I think our quality has increased, because not being able to communicate leads to fights. Okay, of course there are fights in relationships, but you really need communication to solve that fight.

Interviewer:[04:53] So, what makes a relationship low quality, unqualified you? Interviewer.

Speaker:[05:00] Disrespect.

Interviewer:[05:02] Can you explain a little bit more? Why do you think that?

Speaker:[05:06] Of course, if he doesn't respect my values and what I do, if he doesn't give me space, that relationship is already going to suffocate. I mean, even if you talk about it, if he disrespects you despite that, basically, I mean, for example, he likes to watch football and I like to watch TV series. And if I invade and violate his football space and don't allow him and he doesn't allow me to watch TV series, if he doesn't respect me, it's not a really solid relationship.

Interviewer:[05:43] So, you said being able to talk?

Speaker:[05:45] Yes.

Interviewer:[05:46] So would you say then that a high quality relationship, a relationship where you can talk is a high quality relationship?

Speaker:[05:53] Of course, no. Just because everybody is talking, not every situation is solved. In some relationships, things that are talked about are either shelved or swept under the rug. The important thing is to make sure that you can solve that problem. For example, if [Partner's Name] and I have a problem and that problem is not solved at that moment, we will talk about it for another [1-5] days. Until both of us are satisfied, until both of our heads say "oh", that problem is solved. So we talk about it. But let's say it was talked about at that moment, he pretended to understand me. And I pretended to be convinced that he understood me, and the problem exploded at some point. This does not mean that everything that can be talked about is solved. So you need to make sure that it is solved. It is very important to understand the other side. I mean, there is no point in talking if I don't understand him. It is very important to really understand them, to feel their feelings, to empathize with them.

Interviewer:[06:54] So how does a person know that you are in a relationship that is empathetic, that you can be understood? I mean can you tell us more about how a person knows that?

Speaker:[07:06]Of course, let me give you an example. Let's say I said that I was offended by something. For example, it was a very recent topic. It was a conversation about cooking. I don't know how to cook, but [Partner's Name] is someone who knows how to cook much better than me. And I told him, I don't want to learn how to cook or I don't have any interest in it. I don't want you to push me too much in this regard. I said that when these topics are brought up, I feel like it's a pressure on me. If [Partner's Name] is still continuing this topic, if he doesn't warn the people around him, his family, I would say that he doesn't empathize, he doesn't understand me. But if this issue doesn't come up again, if [Partner's Name] can say I will help you when such an issue comes up again, we can learn that I am understood here.

Interviewer:[07:53]So, when would you say that your relationship is understandable? When is it the most, when is it the least?

Speaker:[08:05]What kind of question is that? I don't understand.

Interviewer:[08:09]I'm sorry that I couldn't convey it because you gave a somewhat abstract concept. You can say when your relationship lacks empathy, at least when it lacks empathy. At most, you can say that yes, I am in a relationship where I can understand empathy, where I can talk.

Speaker:[08:27]Everyone has a waking hour and an ass hour. When it coincides with that ass hour clock, I really don't understand [Partner's Name] and [Partner's Name] doesn't understand me. But for example, there is a point where we calm down. You know, where we really calm down, where we return to our own essence. When you get angry, we don't understand each other at all, in any way. I mean, on the contrary, we get very angry, we get furious, we get stubborn with each other. But then we come back to ourselves. We don't talk to each other for an hour or two. For those one or two hours, we miss each other because we don't talk. At the point where we miss it, we can go back and say, you know, I didn't understand you here, I'm

sorry, and we can talk. We think we understand more clearly there. Because the minute we don't talk, you know, you understand. We can say that if it is not in my life, it is really a big gap, a big deficiency. At that point, we understand each other much more clearly, you know, we find a solution, we can talk. At that point, he empathizes and understands me more clearly.

Interviewer:[09:27] So what are the most important things in a relationship for you?

Speaker:[09:32] The most important things. The first is to be able to talk, the second is respect, the third is to give space, the fourth is love and love (sevgi ve aşk), you know, love goes away after a certain point, you know, the excitement of that relationship, of course, after a certain point, the love remains, the thing goes away. But love (sevgi) is always constant and the person who will keep love high is the two people in the relationship. That's why I think it's love (sevgi). Next, I don't know, that's it for now.

Interviewer:[10:07] So do you want to elaborate on that a little bit? Why do you think that?

Speaker:[10:12] Sure. I already gave an example of being able to talk, I gave an example of recognizing space, you know, I actually gave an example of his respect and recognizing space, let me say it again. If he recognizes and respects my values in his space, and I respect and recognize his space, we will have a better quality relationship. Because each person is an individual with their own activities, their own values, and so I think they should recognize them to each other. Other than that, what did I say?

Interviewer:[10:44] You said love.

Speaker: [10:48] Love (sevgi) is like this, love (aşk) is the first beginning of the relationship at first. It's very exciting, the excitement, it's at its peak, it's at a point where you're very much in love and you can't really see anything. But after a certain level of the relationship, love (aşk) goes away, logic comes in, logic and love (sevgi) remain, and you look at the situation between that logic and love (sevgi). You know, you make a comparison between them. Love (sevgi) is like this, if you can't talk to that man, if he doesn't respect you, if he doesn't really care about your values and he doesn't spend time with your values or I don't spend time with his values, there is no love left, it becomes an obligation after a while. So love (sevgi) is very important. In my opinion, love (sevgi) is formed in all of these.

Interviewer:[11:36] So for you, what is love (aşk) for you?

Speaker: [11:41] Love?

Interviewer:[11:42] Uh-huh.

Speaker: [11:43] Love (aşk) is irrationality. Love is passion. It is that excitement at the very peak. It's a time when your blood is so crazy and excited. But when you're fighting a battle between your heart and logic, love is when you listen to your heart and logic disappears.

Interviewer:[12:06] So how important is love in a relationship?

Speaker: [11:12] How important is love in a relationship? Of course love is important in a relationship, but it's very important, it's absolutely very important, but, I mean, for example, my grandfather and my grandmother have been together for [41-45] years, do you think there is love between them? No, they don't. They had that love when they were young. But what left in

the middle is love (sevgi). After a while, after the relationship has been going on for a long time, I think love (aşk) doesn't have much value because love (sevgi) takes the place of love.

Interviewer:[11:49] So how do you know if your lover loves you?

Speaker:[12:55] [Partner's Name] never skips a special day. That's how I know. When I say something I'm upset about, if he repeats it twice, it will never happen a third time. He knows he shouldn't do it. That's how I know. He is with me in the most difficult time. When I get angry, he takes it in his stride. You know a relationship has a destructive and a constructive side. I am destructive and he is constructive. That's how I know, so he can say enough and leave. But if he repairs it, it means he loves me.

Interviewer:[13:26] So what would you say are the challenges in your relationship?

Speaker:[13:33] What are the challenges of our relationship? Actually, the difficulties of our relationship are my stubbornness. We have that one difficulty. Apart from that, the current conditions in [Country] make it a little difficult. Because we are at the stage of getting married. That is a very disturbing point. You know, we think three times while realizing our dreams and wishes. I wonder if this was necessary or not. The conditions of the country are very difficult for us right now. Because we are on the eve of getting married. So we are trying to take a step towards something like that. That is challenging right now. Other than that, thank God our families are fine. There is nothing challenging. [Partner's Name] and I are good with each other, it's just that the situation in the country doesn't match with material things.

Interviewer:[14:22] And do you and your partner fight?

Speaker:[14:25] Of course we do.

Interviewer:[14:28] Can you tell me how often these fights happened?

Speaker:[14:32] Should I say weekly or monthly?

Interviewer:[14:38] Ya...

Speaker:[14:38] It changes like this. I mean, sometimes we fight a lot for a month. Sometimes we don't fight at all for a month. It depends on people's mood and sometimes their experiences. Sometimes we are both very busy because of work. We are having a stressful time. We are trying to catch up with the end of the year or something. It's stressful. We can't agree on something for a moment. That fight grows and grows and grows. Then we look at it. We haven't fought for a month. We sulk for [1-5] days. But the next month, the next weeks we are not sulking at all. So it changes.

Interviewer:[15:13] Well

Speaker:[15:13] That actually depends a little bit on the mood of the person.

Interviewer:[15:16] Can you tell me what these fights were about?

Speaker:[15:22] It comes out of nonsense like that. I mean, there's not much reason. I mean, it comes out of the smallest thing. We explode over food. I don't know. I don't know, something happens. I get mad that he doesn't understand me or something. After that, I know that he actually understands, but I'm waiting for more answers. I'm waiting for him to make more

comments. That's why we fight. Apart from that, we have a long relationship on the eve of marriage. We can't get on a path, we have fights. Other than that, we have nothing else.

Interviewer:[15:54]So how do you resolve these fights?

Speaker:[15:58] We are returning to ourselves. He turns to himself. We don't talk for 1-2 hours. Or sometimes we talk very little the next day. We just let each other know. You know, good morning during the day. I'm over there. You're over there. I'm going there. I'm going here. We communicate minimally during the day. We don't chat much. Because we go back to ourselves. Afterwards, we think why don't we talk? We say, "I didn't hear your voice today," and we miss each other and come back.

Interviewer:[16:30]So what do you think are the other ways to maintain your relationship besides this turning to yourself, not talking?

Speaker:[16:38] After the fight?

Interviewer:[16:40]Uh-huh. The solution to the fight.

Speaker:[16:45]I mean, I don't know any other solution to a fight than not talking and then missing and talking again.

Interviewer:[16:57] So would you say that this relationship is good for you?

Speaker:[17:00]Absolutely.

Interviewer:[17:02] If I ask why.

Speaker:[17:04]Of course because it is good for my soul. So there is someone who feeds me spiritually.

Interviewer:[17:12]Can you give some concrete examples. For example, it can be from your daily life. It could be your work.

Speaker:[17:20]Is it about how it's good for me?

Interviewer:[17:21]Uh-huh

Speaker:[17:24]I think of the simplest, let's say I'm going out and I don't know much about the bus, I don't know the numbers, I don't know which goes where, which does what, or where to get on, where to get off. I don't know these things. [Partner's Name], for example, learns these things. Where is the nearest bus stop. For example, he tells me and I get on. Let me give an example from today. For example, I had to get up at 9:20 at the latest because I had a meeting at 9:30. I went to bed very late at night, the alarm went off and I didn't hear it. [Partner's Name] woke me up at 9.25 for example. You know, you need to wake up because you will be late for the meeting. If he hadn't called, I wouldn't have made it to that meeting. We have things like that. I mean, if I don't wake up, he wakes me up. If I'm hungry, he sends food. When I crave dessert, he sends me dessert. On special days, women have their periods. When I have my period, he buys things and comes. For example, the other day I was very sick. I had the flu for a week. I had no voice. My nose was running a lot. I was weak and stuff. He took a bag of something like this. Because I like chocolate milk. He took vitamins. He took some stuff. He brought it all home, for example.

Interviewer:[18:42] So did this relationship change you?

Speaker:[18:45]Very.

Interviewer:[18:47]How did he change it?

Speaker:[18:51]I grew up in a very traumatic family in my childhood. I mean, because of my father. And I grew up very aggressive. I am very rebellious, I yell a lot, I destroy. [Partner's Name], on the contrary, grew up in a more moderate, more organized family. [Partner's Name] has honed me a lot in this regard. To stay calmer, to think more. I don't know, he made me behave a little more moderately rather than destroying things.

Interviewer:[19:21] And did your partner change during that relationship?

Speaker:[19:25] [Partner's Name] has also changed a lot. Because [Partner's Name] grew up in his family, he grew up very princely because of his mother. So he was not given much responsibility. She raised him in the way a [Nationality] mother would raise a son. He didn't take much responsibility. His sense of responsibility was minimal. He didn't know how to treat a woman. Because he was always treated like a baby and a child. [Partner's Name] is now behaving like a full grown man. So he changed a lot in that process.

Interviewer:[19:55] So is the person you were before the relationship the same person you are now?

Speaker:[20:02] Absolutely not. We are very different people. I mean, the [Name] of [1-5] years ago and the [Name] of now are very different. I'm calmer, I try to be more constructive. I was not used to apologize when I offended someone. But when I offend [Partner's Name], I can go back and apologize.

Interviewer:[20:19] And is the person your partner was before the relationship the same person he is now?

Speaker:[20:23] Definitely not that too, definitely not. I mean he didn't have a sense of responsibility either. His life was all beer and skittles before but now he has a sense of responsibility.

Interviewer:[20:34] So do you feel safe in this relationship?

Speaker:[20:38] This is my safe lane. Safe lane, you know, there's a term for a safe zone. You know, the dangerous zone and the safe zone. [Partner's Name] is my safe lane.

Interviewer:[20:49]Can you explain why you say that?

Speaker:[20:52]Because no harm can come to me in any way with [Partner's Name]. And I know that he will protect me from all evil, that he will not harm me, that if any harm comes to me, he will be the first to be thrown out.

Interviewer:[21:07] Now I am going to show you a scale for us to understand on the screen. I will read it at the same time. If I ask, "My partner usually really listens to me".

Speaker:[21:18] Nine.

Interviewer:[21:18] One, not true at all. Nine is completely true.

Speaker:[21:22] Nine.

Interviewer:[21:22]What would your answer be?

Speaker:[21:23]That's nine.

Interviewer:[21:25] May I know why you answered nine? Why not eight?

Speaker:[21:32]Why not eight? Because when [Partner's Name] and I have a problem, we talk about it for those [1-5] days rather than sweeping it under the carpet. Until it is solved. And he says, you know, if it's not solved, let's talk about it again. And he forces himself to understand.

Interviewer:[21:50]Uh-huh. If I ask, "My partner is usually sensitive to my needs". Again from one to nine.

Speaker:[22:00]I call it an eight.

Interviewer:[22:02]Eight. And why did you answer eight? May I know?

Speaker:[22:08]Because women

Interviewer:[22:08]Why not seven or nine? That's what I'm asking actually.

Speaker:[22:10] Okay, it's like this because [Partner's Name] sometimes can't understand women's moods because we have a changeable nature, which I really had a very changeable nature. Spiritually. Something like this happens instantaneously, for example. I mean, I'll give an example. For example, during these menstrual periods, the stress, the tension we experience, he doesn't understand that momentarily. So, I really understand. What does he do, he gives something material and closes it, because he doesn't understand spirituality very much. I don't know, he brings chocolates, flowers. He takes me out, just to change my mood or something. That's why I said eight.

Interviewer:[22:51] Well, I hope you don't mind in the end. If this is too sensitive for you to share, please feel free to say so. But as a couple, I would like to know more about your physical intimacy. How often do you have sexual intercourse these days?

Speaker:[23:09] We don't have a sexual relationship.

Interviewer:[23:14] Uh-huh. So, how satisfied are you with your sex life?

Speaker:[23:09]I mean, because of our own, how should I put it, family manners, we were against sexual intercourse before marriage on both sides, so we have nothing like that.

Interviewer:[23:30]In terms of intimacy, sexual intercourse.

Speaker:[23:33]Oh, in terms of intimacy, we are both contact addicts, by the way. Especially [Partner's Name] is more addicted to contact than me. You know, he can't do much without touching my hand, touching my arm. Other than that, we hug and hug and hug. You know, hand in hand, arm in arm. He kisses me, I kiss him. But we have nothing sexual.

Interviewer:[23:53] So, how satisfied are you with your relationship in general? Can you see, by the way, does it shine?

Speaker:[24:03]Yeah, yeah, I see. Uh-huh.

Interviewer:[24:05] "Okay, I am dissatisfied." "I am very dissatisfied." and so on.

Speaker:[24:10] I am completely satisfied.

Interviewer:[24:13] Since you said you are completely satisfied, I will show you one more scale, numbered. It's a numbered scale from not at all satisfied to completely satisfied.

Speaker:[24:24] Make that nine.

Interviewer:[24:28] You answered nine. Why? Not 8 or 10.

Speaker:[24:34]10 not. Because nobody is perfect. He has his mistakes and I have my mistakes. That's why I said that. Not 8. Because we are not that bad.

Interviewer:[24:46] So, did your relationship meet your expectations?

Speaker:[24:49] yes, it did.

Interviewer:[24:52] Can you elaborate on that a bit more?

Speaker:[24:54] So it's like this, I don't see my father and I grew up as a girl who longed for a father, who longed for attention. You know, I grew up without the love of a man. But [Partner's Name] did it all by himself. He took care of it, that is, he gave me that attention and affection.

Interviewer:[25:13]We are about to finish. I would like to summarize what we talked about in the last half an hour. You said that you are generally satisfied with your relationship. You considered the most important thing in the relationship as being able to talk, or rather to understand, empathy. You said that love (aşk) goes away over time, love (sevgi) is more important, but what constitutes love is being able to talk, respect, mutual understanding. In general, your relationship met your expectations. But of course you said that you experienced a deficiency due to the mistakes of every human being. So you expressed this, not a deficiency. Were these things true? Is there anything else you want to add?

Speaker:[25:56] That's all true, thank you.

Interviewer:[25:58] Thank you, and now before we finish I would like to talk to you about how I will handle the data. As a research project we want to be as transparent as ethically possible. Therefore, I would like to know which data sharing option is the most suitable for you. I will read you two options and you can choose whichever one you like. The first option is to share some parts of the transcript of our interview. None of the transcript will contain information that can identify you. This way your de-identified interview transcript can be read by other researchers. The second option, if you don't mind, and if you want to be a bit braver, is to share your entire interview transcript, stripped of sensitive and overly identifying details, i.e. anonymized.

Speaker:[26:49] You can anonymize and share.

Interviewer:[26:52]Okay. Let me just finish because in this option there is a very small chance that someone who knows you well will be able to piece together the details from the interview transcript and narrow down the choices between colleagues as to who they believe you are. Again, I would like to emphasize that no sensitive information will be shared. Which of the two options do you prefer?

Speaker:[27:11] You can share the whole thing anonymously.

Interviewer:[27:15] Thank you. I would like you to know that this study has been done in the Philippines, Brazil, the Netherlands, France and the USA. In order for this study to be successful, there is one more thing I would like to ask you, if it is convenient for you. Can you suggest two close people from your life as candidates? I am not going to do a relationship questionnaire with them as a couple, I am just going to ask them to suggest a couple that you don't know. If there are people you can suggest, I'll stop the anxiety now so that the contact number shows up in the recording.

Speaker:[27:48] I mean, there's no one like that. I mean, it's not compatible with this thing. You know, I learned in your survey that you want relationships that are over five years because that's what you want.

Interviewer:[27:58] Yes, but I'm not going to interview the people you suggest, I'm going to ask them to suggest people, maybe a neighbor, maybe a friend who works.

Speaker:[28:09] I think there is no such person.

Interviewer:[28:12] Okay. Thank you very much. For joining us again.

Speaker:[28:15] You're welcome

Interviewer:[28:15] I stop recording.